intervene if matters got too bloody. The Governor, Shri Ashwini Kumar, rang me up several times, asking, even ordering me to intervene, but I told him it was beyond my mandate. It was a Catch-22 situation for us. If we tried to take over the camp, the cadres may fire at us. On the other hand, the locals might view it as us siding with the guilty party, turn antagonistic and vent their ire on us. Why should we squander our goodwill to protect alleged rapists? We even contacted the NSCN (IM) leadership, saying that they should hand over the offenders to us, the AR, and we would ensure their safety till handed over to the police. This offer was not accepted, as it would imply that the NSCN (IM) had ceded their sovereignty to us. Ultimately, the villagers' patience ran out and they just stormed the camp armed with spears, machetes and shotguns, forcing the insurgents to flee. They burned down huts, offices and vehicles leaving only a church standing.[4] This incident underscored the fragility of the law-and-order situation, especially in the face of tribal dynamics that no outsider can ever fathom, as well as the waning influence of the NSCN (IM). The smoke rising from the burning camp could be seen from Kohima, and my friends got a glimpse of the work we do.

Nagaland has sixteen officially recognized tribes, which does not include the Tangkhul Nagas of Manipur, to which Muivah belongs. All the tribes have their own customs and traditions and even their own distinct language. They are fiercely independent and brook no interference in their tribal affairs, and have scant regard for the law of the land. Raiding police stations to capture an offender and then lynching him is not uncommon. One such incident happened in Dimapur itself. A local non-Naga was accused of molestation and had been arrested by the police and lodged in Dimapur Central Jail. A huge mob gathered outside the jail, surrounded it from all

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